

relationships on the table, leaving much room for improvement. We read our colleagues' work as much in search of inspiration and creative disagreement as we look for instruction and conclusive results. In that spirit I can say, do read this book! But do not believe what you read.

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The Life and Times of a Boundary Spanner

Ingmar van Meerkeek and Jurian Edenbos. 2018. *Boundary Spanners in Public Management and Governance: An Interdisciplinary Assessment*. Cheltenham, UK: Edward Elgar Publishing. £80.00. 216 p.

Over recent years, the world of public management and governance has evolved in response to the changing nature and challenges presented by modern societies. The most significant of these include a torrent of complex and cross-boundary “wicked” issues and problems that single organizations and actors cannot resolve by managing autonomously; ever-increasing demands from service users and the wider public for meaningful involvement in shaping and evaluating public services; constant pressure to design and deliver efficient and effective services against a background of limited resources; and, a realization that the needs of future generations must be embraced to achieve a sustainable future. This world is shaped and defined by a scaffolding of a myriad number of boundaries, including organizational, professional, social, cultural, and psychological. Some of these boundaries are real and others socially constructed. They are dynamic and shifting; they can form barriers of variable permeability or conversely help to facilitate interactions; and, they interweave together to form complex policy spaces. Consequently, contemporary public management and governance necessitate the effective management of these boundaries in the course of the pursuit of public policy objectives. This can be achieved partly through structural interventions and policies designed to facilitate and ease cross-boundary management, but, more critically, occur through the management practices and actions of public actors—the boundary spanners with their boundary-spanning behaviors.

The literature on this particular cadre of public actors is comparatively silent, so the work by van Meerkerk and Edelenbos in *Boundary Spanners in Public Management and Governance* is especially welcome. Clearly, public organizations no longer have the luxury, capacity, or discretion to operate independently within a highly interconnected governance framework, and boundary spanning has become a core activity of contemporary public management. And who best to navigate a course through the turbulent waters of complex contemporary public organizations and governments but the boundary spanners? Actors equipped and experienced with the skills and competencies to manage, weave, and bridge the myriad of boundaries that constitute modern public management and governance structures and processes.

This book is the product of a systematic literature review designed to provide a comprehensive and interdisciplinary synopsis and analysis of the topic. The authors' stated intention is to provide an overview of the state of the art on boundary spanners and boundary spanning, paying particular attention to the theoretical underpinnings of the topic, and to advance research on the subject within the context of public management and governance.

The book opens by identifying and discussing the drivers and imperatives for boundary spanning behavior—the complexity of policy issues and problems; fragmentation and functional differentiation; and, the

increasing pressure for participation and co-production by public service users and citizens. The analysis is drawn toward the many different and shifting types of boundary produced by such a system, and the logical demands for boundary spanners to manage and govern in this environment. This constitutes a compelling set of arguments, that needs tempering only by a note of caution around the danger of perceiving all public problems and issues as complex and interdependent when arguably some remain best treated more independently through conventional management practices. The book moves on to consider the theoretical roots and evolution of boundary spanning theory, drawing on a range of interdisciplinary literatures. Such an approach adds considerable richness to the analysis but, inevitably, enhances contestability. It explores and compares three main perspectives—structuralist, role, and action—and from these distills a definition of a boundary spanner. Defining who exactly might be classed as a boundary spanner is far from straightforward. The authors opt for a broad definition that stresses four main components of the role—relational, coordination, mediation, and entrepreneurship. This is intended to identify boundary spanners by their behaviors and activities rather than their formal role in an organizational hierarchy. Consequently, this definition envelopes a potentially large number of actors at different levels of the hierarchy, tasked with different activities and devoting different proportions of their work time to boundary spanning. Questions might be asked as to whether a senior manager and a frontline practitioner, for instance, can be included in the same group, or whether a different classification is necessary. Also, is the definition sufficiently robust and nuanced to apply to boundary spanning actors in the public, private, and third sectors? Or might context make a material difference?

On the question of detecting boundary spanners and their behaviors, the book reviews the research methodologies employed for that purpose. It reveals an equal balance between quantitative and qualitative approaches—each with their respective advantages and disadvantages—and distinguishes three different ways: by specific organizational role or function, by the frequency of the cross-boundary interaction, and by specific activities. It concludes by drawing attention to the dearth of case study, mixed method and longitudinal approaches in the study of this topic. Certainly, these approaches potentially offer the prospect of a greater understanding of the working lives of boundary spanners, and of reflecting the dynamic, complex, contextualized, nuanced and ambiguous nature of their boundary-spanning behaviors and practices. In terms of what the research suggests boundary spanners do, the book identifies four main profiles—fixer, bridger,

broker, and innovator/entrepreneur. The nature and challenges inherent in each of these roles are considered in detail, but although the “interactivity” between them is recognized, and this is a criticism of the literature, not the authors, there is little discussion of how and when these roles are deployed in various permutations to best effect. It is interesting to know whether a single boundary spanner needs to acquire proficiency in all these roles, or whether different boundary spanners, with different boundary spanning role specialisms, need to be assembled to manage particular challenges.

A discussion of the antecedents of boundary spanning behavior is found midway in the book. Arguably, it might have been considered earlier, in conjunction with a clearer exposition of the structure-agency debate*** that must frame any exploration of the role of boundary spanners and their behaviors. Nevertheless, the authors detect four main factors that impact boundary spanning behavior—individual determinants that relate to the competencies and capacities of individual actors; environmental characteristics that define structure; role definition and stressors; and, organizational support and feedback. These factors are used to construct an integral framework of antecedents of boundary spanning behavior. This suggests a complex set of relationships representing more of a tentative research framework rather than a prescriptive analysis of the direction, sequence, combination, and valence of individual factors and relationships. There is certainly no shortage of hypotheses for potential researchers to investigate in the future.

A key, but highly challenging question, concerns what impact boundary spanners have through their boundary-spanning behaviors. Unsurprisingly, the reviewed literature on this subject was limited, but as one might expect, could be categorized broadly into personal impacts on the boundary spanners themselves; those influencing the performance of their employing organizations; and interorganizational outcomes relating to partnerships and alliances of various types, as well as an enhancement of relational capital in a particular geographical area or network, and a contribution to a general discussion of structural factors relating to integration and organizational/resource/sectoral alignment. But, the sad state is that very little research has been undertaken on these different impacts, and there is a clear case for studies designed to measure the performance of boundary spanners and their management in contemporary public management and governance. A clear justification for the promotion and nurturing of boundary spanners is overdue.

In some areas, the book might have offered some additional insights and exploration. For instance, some reflection on, and comparison of boundary spanning

management with other forms and practices of public service management would have been of great interest. What are the comparisons and contrast between them? Do public managers have to switch between different management approaches when tackling different challenges and are different skills and competencies needed? The challenges associated with managing the respective demands of multiple accountabilities are an important area of investigation, and more in-depth exploration is needed into the balance between a boundary spanners' grasp of core knowledge and content on a particular policy area, and their relational and processual skills. The book is relatively silent on the leadership role of boundary spanners, an omission that future contributors in this field of study need to address. Leadership is an activity that is relevant at different levels in the organizational hierarchy, and the nature of boundary spanning management impacts on leadership styles, approaches, and practices. In terms of theoretical insights, the contribution of boundary object theory is one that offers considerable potential in this area of study. Lastly, the education, training, and development of boundary spanners are other areas that might have received greater attention, particularly for the benefit of policymakers and practitioners. If cross-boundary management is a core management activity of the future, there is a pressing need to ensure that public

managers are appropriately trained and equipped in the necessary skills and competencies.

Although this book is considered suitable for a range of audiences, its primary appeal is likely to be academics, researchers, and students. There are clear lessons for policy and practice in this area, a number of which have been identified, but public managers and practitioners tend to be drawn to more prescriptive material in the form of toolbooks, practice guides, and key lessons to guide their practice, and may perhaps find the evidence somewhat too theoretical and academic for their needs. But be under no illusion, this is essential reading for all those interested in understanding the nature, role and behaviors of this important actor in the collaborative spaces of public management and governance, now and into the future. It is a well-written, structured and comprehensive systematic review on the subject, and represents the most up-to-date exploration of boundary spanners and their behaviors. In particular, it offers a rich research agenda for future academics and students.

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Journal of Public Administration Research and Theory **Police as Emergency Responders: Organizational or Personal Resilience?**

Terri M. Adams and Leigh R. Anderson. *Policing in Natural Disasters: Stress, Resilience, and the Challenges of Emergency Management*. Philadelphia: Temple University Press, 2019. 221 pp.

Public administration's scholarship regarding police departments and officers has been an important avenue for understanding representative bureaucracy and street-level bureaucracy theories, as well as other topics related to organizational and individual behavior. This has provided important information regarding bureaucratic and organizational decision making, but studies typically focus on the

everyday activities of police departments and officers. In *Policing After Disasters: Stress, Resilience, and the Challenges of Emergency Management*, Terri M. Adams and Leigh R. Anderson focus on the role that police officers play as first responders in natural disasters. The authors do this by examining qualitative and quantitative data collected directly from police officers after three incidents: Hurricane Katrina,